On Taste: Why the Rarest Skill in Tech Cannot Be Automated

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1. Source Info

Title: On Taste (compiled from multiple sources)
Authors: Paul Graham, Julie Zhuo, Gaurav Vohra, Emil Kowalski, Anu Atluru, Steve Jobs
Date: Various (2002-2026)

- **Sources:**
- Paul Graham, "Taste for Makers" (February 2002): https://www.paulgraham.com/taste.html
- Julie Zhuo, "On Taste" Parts 1-3, The Looking Glass: https://medium.com/the-year-of-the-looking-glass/on-taste-part-i-1993cd56e9ac
- Gaurav Vohra, "Taste to Resonance," Growth by Gaurav: https://substack.gauravvohra.com/p/taste-resonance
- Emil Kowalski, "Developing Taste": https://emilkowal.ski/ui/developing-taste
- Anu Atluru, "Taste Is Eating Silicon Valley," Working Theorys: https://www.workingtheorys.com/p/taste-is-eating-silicon-valley
- Steve Jobs on taste (two video clips): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Og7gC1GJPF8 and https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=UiOzGI4MqSU

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2. Executive Summary

Taste is not subjective preference; it is a trainable faculty of discernment that determines whether products, campaigns, and experiences achieve genuine resonance or merely functional adequacy. Six independent sources spanning two decades converge on this claim: Graham's 14 design principles, Zhuo's self-calibration framework, Vohra's reach-versus-resonance distinction, Kowalski's practitioner playbook from Linear, Atluru's

macro thesis that taste is eating Silicon Valley, and Jobs's original articulation that exposure to the best human achievements is the path. The recipe for great work, as Graham puts it, is "very exacting taste, plus the ability to gratify it." In 2026, with AI commoditizing execution and everyone's software "good enough," the ability to discern what is worth making has become the bottleneck.

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3. Key Insights & Frameworks

3.1 Taste Is Not Subjective: Paul Graham's Foundation

Graham's 2002 essay attacks the belief that taste is purely personal. He traces this to childhood, when parents say "you like it your way, he likes it his way" to prevent disputes, then later insist Leonardo is a "great artist," creating an unresolved contradiction most people carry into adulthood.

His demolition is elegant: if taste were purely personal, improvement would be impossible, because whatever you like is what you like. But designers, writers, and engineers routinely recognize their earlier work as worse than their current work. This recognition of improvement proves taste exists on a scale, positions on that scale are not arbitrary, and movement along the scale is possible through deliberate effort. This transforms taste from a fixed personality trait into a skill, and every other insight in this essay depends on this foundational claim.

3.2 The Fourteen Principles of Good Design

Graham identifies structural properties that recur across mathematics, engineering, painting, architecture, and writing wherever humans solve hard problems well:

Good design is simple. The best solutions use fewer elements. "When you're forced to be simple, you're forced to face the real problem." Complexity often masks weak substance.

Good design is timeless. If something looks dated, it was probably driven by fashion. Graham's practical strategy: aim to appeal to both 1500 and the present, because fashion changes but fundamental quality does not.

Good design solves the right problem. A stove with burner dials in a row looks clean but forces mental mapping. Dials in a square match the actual problem geometry. The most important design decisions redefine the problem rather than polish the solution.

Good design is suggestive. Jane Austen creates vivid scenes with minimal description. Software should offer basic elements users combine freely, like Lego bricks, rather than dictating uses.

Good design is often slightly funny. Confident creators do not take themselves too seriously. Graham connects humor to strength: seriousness signals insecurity, lightness signals mastery. Think Hitchcock's cameos, Bruegel's peasant paintings, Shakespeare's plays.

Good design is hard. Constraints breed elegance. An architect with a difficult site and small budget produces better work because "fashions and flourishes get knocked aside by the difficult business of solving the problem at all." Wild animals look beautiful because they have hard lives.

Good design looks easy. The conversational tone of good writing comes only on the eighth rewrite. Leonardo's minimal line drawings demand near perfection; the slightest error collapses the whole thing. Thousands of hours of practice train the unconscious mind.

Good design uses symmetry. Repetition and recursion appear at every level of great work. The Eiffel Tower is a recursive solution. But symmetry carries a danger: "it can be used as a substitute for thought."

Good design resembles nature. Nature has been solving problems for billions of years. Boats have spines and ribs. As computing power grows, we can imitate nature's methods (genetic algorithms), not just its results.

Good design is redesign. Experts plan to throw early work away. Leonardo's drawings show five or six attempts per line. The Porsche 911's distinctive back emerged from redesigning an awkward prototype. Oil paint helped painters address the human figure because it allowed blending and revision.

Good design can copy. The greatest masters achieve a selflessness where they just want the right answer, regardless of who found part of it first. Attitudes cycle through three phases: unknowing imitation, conscious originality-seeking, and mature correctness-seeking where borrowing is natural.

Good design is often strange. Euler's Formula, the SR-71, Lisp. Graham suspects strangeness may indicate something beyond our current comprehension. The only style worth having is the one you cannot avoid.

Good design happens in chunks. Fifteenth-century Florence, the Bauhaus, Xerox PARC, the Manhattan Project. "Nothing is more powerful than a community of talented people working on related problems."

Good design is often daring. Every era harbors beliefs people defend fiercely. Renaissance art seemed shockingly secular. Einstein's relativity remained unaccepted in France until the 1950s. The recipe: examine where conventional wisdom diverges from truth.

3.3 Julie Zhuo: What If Your Taste Is the Problem?

Zhuo's three-part series, written from her experience as VP of Design at Facebook, explores the emotional dimension Graham deliberately sidesteps. Where Graham asks "what are the properties of good design?", Zhuo asks "how do I know if I can even recognize good design?"

Part 1 opens with a personal story. As a nine-year-old, Zhuo was convinced she was a talented singer. She practiced nightly, auditioned for a solo with total confidence, and lost. Years later, recording herself, she discovered the truth: she sounded, in her words, "like some sort of tipsy animal." The notes that sounded bright in the shower were muddled and warbly.

This surfaces a fear haunting anyone in creative work: if her singing self-assessment was completely wrong, what else might she be delusional about? The singing story becomes a metaphor for the central anxiety of creative practice: you might not be able to trust your own judgment, and you might not know that you cannot trust it.

Zhuo then introduces Ira Glass's famous observation about the "taste gap": all creative

people enter their field because they have good taste, but for the first years, their work does not match their taste. Glass frames this as encouraging: keep working and your skills catch up. Zhuo identifies Glass's blind spot: what if your taste itself is miscalibrated? If your aesthetic judgment is flawed, no amount of practice closes the gap, because you are aiming at the wrong target.

Part 2 moves from anxiety to diagnosis. Zhuo describes attending weekly portfolio reviews as a junior designer. She could identify obviously bad work, but struggled to distinguish between genuinely strong portfolios. Different colleagues reached different conclusions about the same work. This forced an uncomfortable question: did her own standards need calibrating?

Her solution is "the understand-the-experts test": for any field, can you grasp why people you admire hold their opinions about quality? You do not need to agree with their assessments. But you need to understand their reasoning well enough to engage in meaningful disagreement. If you cannot articulate why a respected colleague sees one portfolio as superior to another, your taste in that domain needs development.

Part 3 offers a six-step framework:

1. **Believe good taste exists.** Mirrors Graham's argument against subjectivity.
2. **Identify people with good taste.** Research whom they admire. Follow the chain of influence backward.
3. **Immerse yourself in their values.** Use their products. Study their portfolios. Watch what they praise and criticize.
4. **Always be critiquing.** Move beyond "cool" or "sucks." Ask: what worked, why, and whether you agree.
5. **Calibrate with others.** Zhuo credits 73% of her design education to collaborative conversations, not formal training.
6. **Practice the craft.** Understanding craft at an intimate level develops comprehension that observation alone cannot provide.

3.4 Gaurav Vohra: From Taste to Resonance

Vohra's essay bridges individual taste and growth outcomes through the distinction between

reach and resonance.

Reach is impressions, followers, visibility; it can be purchased with sufficient budget. **Resonance** is emotional connection, lasting impact, affinity; it must be earned through taste. Jay Acunzo captures it: "Awareness is a proxy for what we really want. We want affinity."

The paradox: reach without resonance exists (spend enough and people see your work), but resonance without reach struggles algorithmically. The crucial nuance is that resonance eventually generates its own reach through word of mouth, while reach without resonance requires perpetual spending.

His examples: Duolingo's reputational recovery through unhinged social media personality. Linear's community appeal built through principled design that other companies copy. Superhuman's onboarding, where every new user gets a personal call, not because it scales, but because the founders recognized the first experience with a premium product should itself feel premium. Users describe it to others unprompted, generating word-of-mouth no ad spend could replicate.

Vohra then offers six foundations for developing taste in growth work:

1. **Learn the rules.** Master foundational frameworks across growth, product, and design. Understand statistics, deliverability, psychology before breaking rules effectively.
2. **Gather data.** Actively consume growth artifacts. Specific resources: User Onboard for onboarding teardowns, Good Better Best for pricing analysis, Growth.Design for case studies, Really Good Emails for campaigns.
3. **Practice discernment.** Evaluate experiences on both reach and resonance. When you encounter a campaign, ask not just "did it convert?" but "how did it make me feel? Will I remember this next week?"
4. **Effortful creation.** The Confucian formulation: "I hear and I forget. I see and I remember. I do and I understand." Personally writing copy, scaffolding onboarding flows, designing experiments builds taste through muscle memory.
5. **Seek feedback.** Request resonance feedback from practitioners you admire. Listen to public critique alongside private feedback.
6. **Repeat.** Developing taste requires iterative execution over 100+ campaigns, launches, or projects. The shift from taster to tastemaker is gradual and lifelong.

3.5 Emil Kowalski: The Practitioner's Path

Kowalski's essay, from his experience at Linear, is the most concise and actionable source. He frames the argument through an automotive analogy: when automobiles first appeared, consumers showed no preference for color or design because horses were the competition. Now that cars are commoditized, quality and details matter immensely. Software has reached the same inflection point. Functionality alone no longer differentiates.

His three strategies:

1. **Surround yourself with great work.** Steve Jobs stated it plainly: "It comes down to trying to expose yourself to the best things that humans have done and then try to bring those things into what you're doing." Build a curated inventory of tastemakers.
2. **Think about why you like something.** Move beyond gut reactions. Study creative choices methodically. This develops the analytical vocabulary that separates "I like it" from understanding.
3. **Practice.** Seek feedback from credible sources. Accept that your initial work will disappoint you; that gap between taste and execution is a positive indicator (see 3.6). Persistence closes the gap.

Kowalski's definition is precise: "Good taste isn't merely personal preference; it's a trained instinct, the capacity to perceive beyond surface-level aesthetics and recognize excellence."

3.6 The Ira Glass Taste Gap: Why Early Work Disappoints

Glass's observation provides the psychological bridge between knowing what good taste looks like and producing work that meets your own standards. All creative people enter their field because they have good taste, but for the first years, their output does not match their standards. The gap between taste and skill is normal: the disappointment means your taste exceeds your current ability, and skill improves with volume. Glass's prescription: do a huge volume of work on a deadline.

Zhuo's contribution (see 3.3) is identifying Glass's blind spot: what if your taste itself is miscalibrated? This is why the understand-the-experts test matters as an external calibration mechanism.

3.7 Anu Atluru: Taste Is Eating Silicon Valley

Atluru makes the most expansive strategic claim: taste has become the primary competitive advantage in technology, paralleling how software itself was the advantage a decade ago. "In a world of scarcity, we treasure tools. In a world of abundance, we treasure taste."

The argument proceeds in three stages:

Stage 1: Software has commoditized. Through technological advancement, decreasing costs, democratization of coding, and AI, the barrier to building functional software has collapsed. "Everyone's software is good enough."

Stage 2: Taste is the new differentiator. When every competitor can build the same features, what separates winners is how products look, feel, and connect emotionally. Taste manifests as the combination of history, design, user experience, and embedded values that creates resonance. It is opinionated by nature: "bad taste is better than no taste," per Arnold Bennett.

Stage 3: Taste creates distribution. This is Atluru's most original insight. Products with strong aesthetic identity generate word-of-mouth and community affinity. Users do not just use these products; they identify with them. Taste helps with distribution, and distribution reinforces taste.

Her examples: Arc took on legacy browsers with design and brand as core selling points. Linear is known equally for its principled design and its frequently copied landing pages as for its functionality; "Linear-style" has become its own aesthetic category. In AI, general-purpose chatbot competition has shifted beyond technical merits to how products make users feel. Founders now compete against celebrities and influencers who bring distribution and cultural advantages. Investors bet on "taste-driven founders who capture cultural zeitgeist." Even VCs are redesigning websites, writing manifestos, launching podcasts.

Atluru is honest about tensions. Utility still demands respect. More people think they have taste than reality supports. Taste cannot be copied directly, though superficial artifacts can be imitated with lag. And there are gatekeeping risks around who sets standards.

3.8 Steve Jobs: The Original Articulation

Both YouTube clips capture Jobs stating the same core idea with characteristic directness. In the 1995 interview, he describes taste as exposure to the best human achievements and bringing those things into your work (see 3.5 for the quote). In the 1996 PBS documentary, he delivers his famous critique of Microsoft: the company makes mediocre products not because its engineers lack technical skill, but because the organization lacks taste. This is arguably the most influential use of the word "taste" in the technology industry's history, establishing that taste is a strategic differentiator determining whether products are adequate or exceptional.

Jobs's framing anticipates every subsequent thinker: Graham describes what taste looks like in practice, Zhuo describes how to develop it, Vohra connects it to growth outcomes, Kowalski provides the daily practice, and Atluru identifies the macro trend making Jobs's 1995 insight more relevant in 2026 than when he first said it.

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4. Tactical Playbook

4.1 Build a Taste Library

Curate a collection of the best examples in your domain. For growth practitioners, Vohra (see 3.4) recommends: User Onboard, Good Better Best, Growth.Design, Siteinspire, Really Good Emails. Review regularly; the goal is internalizing what quality feels like so you recognize its absence instinctively.

4.2 Apply the Understand-the-Experts Test Weekly

Pick one piece of work each week and identify someone with demonstrated taste who has an opinion about it. Can you articulate why they hold that opinion? If not, research until you can. This is Zhuo's external calibration mechanism (see 3.3) in action.

4.3 Create Before You Delegate

Before handing a brief to a designer, copywriter, or AI tool, attempt a rough version yourself. Doing builds understanding that watching cannot (see 3.4, Vohra's "effortful creation"). Experience the decision-making process firsthand.

4.4 Evaluate Campaigns on Resonance, Not Just Reach

Add a qualitative layer beyond quantitative metrics (see 3.4 for the reach/resonance distinction). Ask: will anyone remember this in a week? Does it create affinity or just awareness? Would someone share this because it is genuinely good, not because they were incentivized?

4.5 Study Adjacent Disciplines

Graham's principles (see 3.2) apply across mathematics, architecture, painting, and writing because taste transcends domain boundaries. Growth practitioners who study typography, film editing, product design, or cooking develop cross-disciplinary instincts that surface in their growth work.

4.6 Seek Honest Critique, Not Validation

Find colleagues whose taste you respect and engage in detailed analysis (see 3.3, Zhuo's Step 5). Vague praise develops nothing. Specific critique ("the hierarchy is confusing because the secondary CTA is more visually prominent than the primary") develops everything.

4.7 Accept the 100+ Iteration Timeline

Vohra estimates 100+ campaigns, launches, or projects (see 3.4). Set realistic expectations. Focus on learning rate rather than current output quality. Each iteration should include

explicit reflection on what you would do differently.

4.8 Reject the "AI Can Handle It" Reflex

When AI generates technically acceptable content, pause before accepting. Apply Graham's principles (see 3.2): is it simple? Does it solve the right problem? Is it suggestive? Does it have humor? AI outputs that pass a technical bar often fail the taste bar because they default to convention rather than challenging it. Knowing what to reject is as important as knowing what to create (see 3.8).

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5. Contrarian / Non-Obvious Takes

5.1 The Taste Gap Is a Feature, Not a Bug

Most people experience the gap between taste and skill as painful (see 3.6). The deeper reframe: the gap is the most valuable signal in your creative practice. A growth engineer who thinks "this is fine but not great" has better taste than one who thinks everything they ship is excellent. The dissatisfaction is the compass. Kill the gap by improving your skill, but never by lowering your standards. This has organizational implications: teams that celebrate "good enough" are actively eroding their taste, while teams that feel productive discomfort are developing it.

5.2 Bad Taste Is Better Than No Taste

This is counterintuitive. Bad taste means opinionated choices that happen to be wrong. No taste means generic, inoffensive, forgettable output. Bad taste can be calibrated; no taste cannot, because there is nothing to calibrate. The most dangerous position in growth marketing is not making bold creative choices that fail; it is making no creative choices at all

and hiding behind best practices. This explains why some of the most successful brands started with polarizing aesthetics they later refined, while "safe" brands rarely break through.

5.3 AI Makes Taste More Valuable, Not Less

The common fear is that AI democratizes taste by making good design accessible to everyone. The evidence runs opposite. When everyone has "good enough" AI-generated output, "good enough" stops being enough. Products that feel AI-generated (technically correct, emotionally flat) become the new mediocrity. The bar rises, not falls. This creates a widening gap between AI-assisted mediocrity and taste-driven excellence, which is why Emily Kramer's GACC framework matters more than ever: creative quality was always the variable, and its variance just increased.

5.4 Taste Clusters Geographically and Socially, Creating Inequality

Graham observes that great design happens in chunks (see 3.2). If taste develops through proximity to others with taste, access to taste development is unevenly distributed. People in strong design communities develop taste faster than isolated practitioners. The "just develop taste" advice, while correct, is harder to follow outside taste-rich environments. Remote work and online communities partially address this, but the clustering effect creates genuine competitive inequality that most taste discourse ignores. Elena Verna's anti-pattern #5 (micro-optimizations as a substitute for vision) is more prevalent in taste-poor environments, suggesting the clustering effect compounds over time.

5.5 Most Growth Teams Optimize for Reach When They Should Optimize for Resonance

The highest-performing products (Notion, Figma, Linear, Superhuman) all grew primarily through resonance (see 3.4, 3.7). Yet most growth experiments maximize reach metrics (impressions, clicks, conversions) because reach is easier to measure and teams are incentivized on short-term results. This creates a systematic under-investment in the dimension that matters most for long-term compounding growth. ICE/PIE scoring frameworks should include taste as an explicit input: when scoring Confidence, ask whether the

experiment reflects genuine insight or mechanical optimization; when scoring Impact, ask whether success would create resonance or just a temporary lift.

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6. What to Revisit

- **Paul Graham's 14 principles (3.2)** : Before any major product or campaign design decision. The principles are domain-agnostic and serve as a structural integrity checklist. https://www.paulgraham.com/taste.html
- **Zhuo's understand-the-experts test (3.3, Part 2)** : When you cannot articulate why one design or campaign is better than another. Concrete diagnostic for taste gaps.
- **Vohra's reach vs. resonance framework (3.4)** : During quarterly planning when setting growth targets. Ask whether your metrics reward resonance or only reach.
- **Atluru's "Taste Is Eating Silicon Valley" (3.7)** : When making competitive strategy decisions. The strategic context for why taste-driven differentiation is not optional.
- **Kowalski's three-step practice (3.5)** : When your taste feels plateaued. The surround-analyze-practice cycle is simple enough to restart at any point.
- **Ira Glass on the taste gap (3.6)** : When early-stage work disappoints you. The gap is evidence your standards are correctly calibrated.

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7. Sources & Further Reading

1. **Paul Graham, "Taste for Makers" (2002)** - https://www.paulgraham.com/taste.html

The foundational essay identifying 14 principles of good design across mathematics, engineering, architecture, and writing.

2. **Julie Zhuo, "On Taste" Parts 1-3, The Looking Glass** - Part 1: https://medium.com/the-year-of-the-looking-glass/on-taste-part-i-1993cd56e9ac / Part 2:

https://medium.com/the-year-of-the-looking-glass/on-taste-part-2-e4ebc15d5d36 / Part 3: https://medium.com/the-year-of-the-looking-glass/on-taste-part-3-d7d9f069f0b2

The emotional and developmental dimensions of taste, including the six-step framework and the understand-the-experts test for self-calibration.

3. **Gaurav Vohra, "Taste to Resonance," Growth by Gaurav** - https://substack.gauravvohra.com/p/taste-resonance

Bridges taste to growth through reach-versus-resonance, with six practical foundations and specific resource recommendations.

4. **Emil Kowalski, "Developing Taste"** - https://emilkowal.ski/ui/developing-taste

Concise practitioner guide from a Linear design engineer. The automobile analogy is one of the clearest framings of why taste matters now.

5. **Anu Atluru, "Taste Is Eating Silicon Valley," Working Theorys** - https://www.workingtheorys.com/p/taste-is-eating-silicon-valley

The strategic macro argument: taste is to 2026 what software was to 2011. How taste creates distribution and why the sector where taste does not matter is shrinking.

6. **Steve Jobs on taste (1995 interview)** - https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Og7gC1GJPF8

The original articulation that exposure to the best human achievements is the path to taste.

7. **Steve Jobs, "Microsoft has no taste" (1996 PBS documentary)** - https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=UiOzGI4MqSU

Established taste as a strategic differentiator, not an aesthetic luxury.

8. **Ira Glass on the taste gap** - https://www.themarginalian.org/2014/01/29/ira-glass-success-daniel-sax/

The canonical articulation of why early creative work disappoints. Referenced by Zhuo and Kowalski.

9. **D&AD: "Why Taste Will Become the Rarest and Most Coveted Commodity"** - https://www.dandad.org/insights/features/why-taste-will-become-the-rarest-and-most-coveted-commodity

The design industry's perspective on taste in the AI era; includes a five-step framework for developing taste as a competitive moat.

10. **Rory Sutherland on Taste: Paul Graham's Principles, Decoded** - https://ourglass.wine/blog/rory-sutherland-taste-paul-graham

Behavioral science lens on Graham's design principles, connecting taste to the psychology of perception and decision-making.